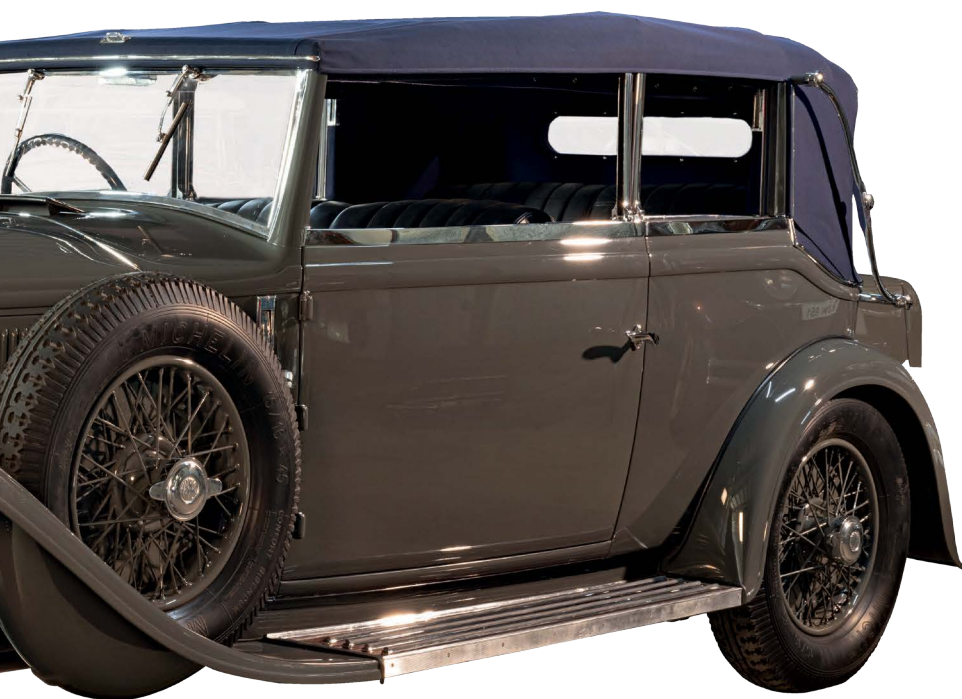


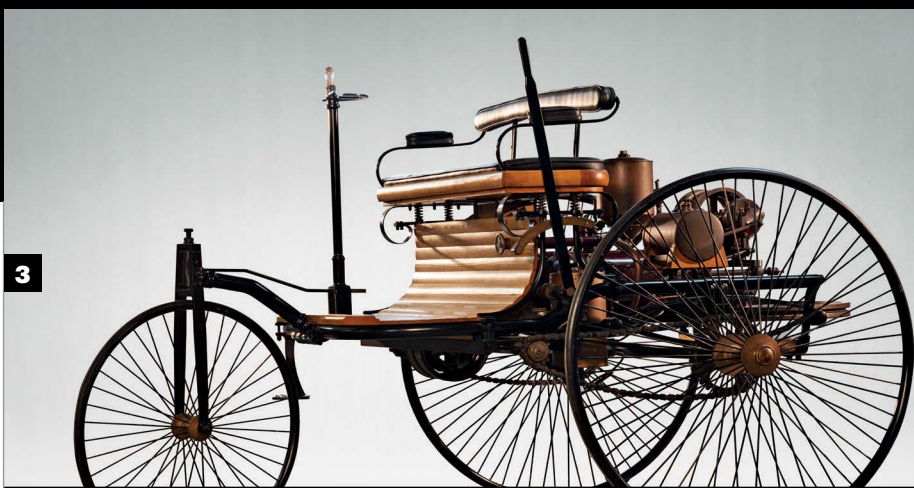
ence of a few lakh rupees and now they are 300 times that price,” he says regretfully.

If you are planning to start a collection of classic cars from an investment point of view, then it is advisable to buy cars based on a coherent theme such as the manufacturer, the model, or the body style. A small but co-ordinated collection can be both more valuable and more interesting than an array of classic cars without any connection to each other.

Another thing to keep in mind when buying a vintage car from an investment point of view is the provenance of the car. “If the car was owned by a Maharaja, the price can go up by 30 per cent,” chuckles Mohan. He himself has bought nearly 150 cars



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1 1938 Armstrong Siddeley seven-passenger limousine specially commissioned for the Maharaja of Kapurthala

2 1932 Lancia Astura, Series-2, Pininfarina

3 1886 Benz Motorwagen, the first automobile invented by Carl Benz

from various erstwhile Maharajas. A favourite of his is a Bentley that was especially manufactured for the Maharani of Baroda in 1948. “It’s one of a kind,” says Mohan proudly.

Besides private auctions, another option to purchase vintage cars is from government sales. “Some of the government ITIs and engineering colleges have old cars that they then sell off,” says Mohan.

The oldest car in Mohan’s collection is the 1886 Benz Motorwagen. It is the first automobile invented by Carl Benz and it runs on benzene. “It can run on a bottle of whiskey also,” smiles Mohan.

The maintenance of a vintage car is also a difficult process. It is important to take it for a spin regularly to ensure it stays in running condition. “But avoid driving in the rains as the wheels can get stuck,” advises Mohan. You also need to find the right storage solution. Besides keeping it safe from theft and damage, classic cars must be protected from the elements as much as they can, as they are often less weather-proof than newer models.

Vintage cars are more than a utilitarian vehicle. These automotive relics of a bygone era evoke a sense of romance and nostalgia. So go ahead and get yourself a new set of wheels, but make sure they are over five decades old. **BT**

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